

**Special Education Subcommittee Meeting - 11.18.2021**  
**Via Zoom**

Melanie McLaughlin, Chair  
Member Paul Ruseau also present.

Shared screen with minutes from October meeting.

Proposed Special Education Problem of Practice

Tonya Sullivan, co-chair Medford SEPAC and parent; are there thoughts on any programming in the summer for Unified Sports or adaptive sports? Camp?

Joan Bowen: Last year we spoke about how do we add recreational activities to the extended school year programming. We could put a work group together as to what people would like to see? Is this something we pursue through Medford Rec or Summer Fun.

Tonya Sullivan: We had a meeting with the Mayor and Medford Rec. last night so I am just wondering what the point of view of administration is? What the regulations might look like with this.

Melanie McLaughlin: Last night, Chenin Pelaquin spoke of other districts working with recreation departments to give students ESY needs and SEL needs met. What I heard is that often times, we know meaningful inclusion is the goal but sometimes hasn't been done. We see that the rec dept. Does need training around inclusive programming.

Alex Lauric, co-chair of SEPAC and parent: what is happening with bringing Carla's program to the Middle school and expanding the disability awareness curriculum?

Melanie McLaughlin: Suzanna Campbell can give us an update as to the Disability Awareness curriculum. Carla Andre has taken adapt. Phys ed. Position.

Joan Bowen: Suzanna created Disability Awareness PD program for staff. Parents and students come to talk about disabilities. Identified need for disability awareness curriculum in our schools. This year we are piloting it at three different grade levels. Each level is being introduced to one type of disability. We hope to expand it over the years so students learn about disabilities in a natural way over the 12 years of their education. Suzanna will do her workshop again in early spring for staff and administrators.

Melanie: We will make sure we invite Suzanna to the next meeting. We can encourage data collection around the program so we can make policy recommendations to expand it.

Joan: Suzanna is working on getting data and feedback from teachers as to what is working and not working. I will talk to her about presenting data to the subcommittee.

Alex Lauric: Should we talk to the Curriculum Directors about how to place this curriculum in the classrooms?

Joan: We have spoken with the Humanities Director, Nicole Chiesa.

Mea Mustone has joined the meeting.

Carla: Common Ground still exists. Waypoint Adventures came and brought the kids into the Fells during Common Ground. I don't know the details but a new teacher is doing this twice a cycle.

Tonya: SEPAC sponsored the hike in the Fells. It is continuing but I am not sure what else is planned.

Melanie: We spoke of Best Buddies at the Middle School (reverse inclusion model). The purpose of this meeting is to identify whether we want to explore that as a group.

Tonya: maybe revisit what the goals have been to make sure they don't drop off as we take on new goals. I don't know that anything has been done with Best Buddies. COVID has put a pause with some things. I don't know that we want to take on new goals when old goals haven't come to fruition.

Paul: We can send recommendations to the full committee to vote. I have no concerns about goals but it is important to note that no one should do anything until we have gone to a full vote.

Melanie: We did vote on continuing the Disability Awareness curriculum last year. I appreciate your concern.

Paul: I know we vote on the minutes but I don't see motions coming out the minutes to implement this program. This committee can make a recommendation to expand a program next year. We have to write the words so that they can be sent up to the subcommittee.

Melanie: It is not our responsibility to make curriculum recommendations. We had made motions at the end of the year to make policy recommendations.

Mea Mustone: I was thinking that having two girls at the Andrews, the CCSR is doing a food drive at Bread of Life. Maybe the Buddy program can participate in this?

Melanie: we had parents look into the Best Buddies program. We had decided temporarily to look at internal avenues instead of working with Best Buddies. We can decide as a subcommittee that we would like to pursue Best Buddies. It is more affordable than it had been in the past.

Mea: Could I work with someone at the AMS to see about having this be a short, successful service project? Am I overstepping? The sewing club is going to sew the toiletry bags. The students will compile the items.

MEV: It would be most appropriate to work with Mr. Skorker on this. I will reach out to him.

Joan: You can connect with me and I can reach out to the AMS special education staff.

Mea: This is all together at the beginning. I am thinking more in the Spring.

Alex: We are looking for reverse inclusion options for during the school day as well as for after school. Can we explore ways for it to be done during the school day potentially?

Joan: Transportation should not be a barrier for students to be able to participate. We would just need to know ahead of time. They have every right to access extracurricular activities. It just takes a little bit of planning to set it up.

Mea: I will email you tomorrow Joan.

Melanie: Again, I would like to put to the floor: would you like to make recommendations for the problem of practice?

Are folks wanting to continue to work on meaningful inclusion and building friendships in and out of school?

Raise of hands?

Our next meeting is in January for this group (Special Education). We can look into best buddies, disability awareness, CCSR projects.

Mea: Yes for friendships. There are no strangers, just friends you haven't met yet.

All raising hands to agree on goal.

Melanie: Looking at calendar, Dec. 16 is BH session. Jan 20 is the next Special Education Sub. meeting. Gives us two months to work on these issues

Meeting Adjourned.